UNFOLDING THE PEDAGOGIC SPIRAL

The vision of Helikos Pedagogy

by Giovanni Fusetti, January 2024

Over the last 30 years I've been teaching extensively, constantly studying and researching in order to deepen my relationship with this amazing field of practice and knowledge. I always look at my pedagogic journey with the curiosity of the player who, at the end of an improvisation, asks that famous question: *what is the theme?*

What are the drives that are moving me, the urgencies that have pushed and pulled me through all these years? What are the dynamics of the pedagogic clay that I love so much working with?

Each class, each workshop, each program, each school is a form.
Each form is a mask. A pedagogic mask.
What is the clay from which this form emerges?
Which are the skills of the pedagogic creator?

I have searched for the essence of these questions, processing and composting the many years of daily work in the pedagogic garden. Season after season at the *Lecoq School*, at *Kiklos*, at *Helikos*, as well as in my pedagogic travels and workshops around the world, I have always been looking at the fundamental dynamics that vibrate at the core of the vision.

When I chose the name *Helikos*, I was looking for a symbol of evolution: something that moves and is moved by intimate necessity, a process that follows a self-regulating principle of *trans-formation*.

The Spiral connects two directions in the process of becoming: it expresses ex-tension, cyclical continuity and variation, evolution in the unfolding movement of creation, perpetual balance between expansion and contraction. Balance in the unbalance. Pulsation.

The Spiral is the manifestation of the evolution of a state of consciousness. It progresses inwardly and outwardly and proceeds towards the center as well as away from it. It originates from both directions.

The choice of the Spiral as a symbol is connected with the vision of a school and a pedagogy as forms in permanent evolution. I like to see the Spiral as a metaphor of the journey of the artist and poet through a training that is always connected with its beginning, as well as being projected into the future an into its becoming.

It is also a symbolic way to honor the lineage of all those who have been masters to me

and whose legacy is nurturing the evolution of my work: mentors, teachers, colleagues, students ... and Nature itself, who has hidden the Spiral in flowers, bodies and shells, mysteriously encoded in the Fibonacci sequence.

It is now time for another cycle of the Spiral, a new number in the sequence, a number that is equal to the sum of all the previous ones.

The Foundations of Helikos Pedagogy: theatre training as the Journey of Initiation of the Actor-Creator

Theatre is play: imitation, transposition and re-invention of the world. It's a very ancient human expression, based on the ecstasy of playing, the awareness of the dynamics of life and the rigor of technique. It's a space in which life is represented, celebrated and transformed through the body. This process requires phenomenological passion and curiosity in the obser- vation of the mystery and wonder of life in movement. The Actor-Creator is a poet who enters the journey of discovering the world and manifests the world's beauty through poetic forms. A poet of ecstasy. Their body is the body of the world.

My pedagogic work is, and will be, a constantly evolving process. It's an alchemy in which I distill the best of my findings. The latest version is always the most up to date.

The integration of multiple practices has lead to the creation and development of a pedagogic tree with multiple roots and branches.

A Pedagogy of Movement

The body is the first space of perception, learning and knowledge for the human being, the foundation of the artistic experience and the theatrical language. The experience and study of the body moving in space leads to the progressive discovery of the principles of movement and of artistic creation, as well as of human consciousness. Nature, *physis* in ancient Greek language, is our master. We are all students of the movements of life.

A Pedagogy of Play

Before being *Homo sapiens*, we are *Homo ludens*. Play *(le jeu)* exists when the rigor of technique joins with the pleasure of the artist. The "playing" actor represents and reinvents the world, revealing its poetic richness in an ecstatic process. A poet through gestures, working with rigorous fun and disciplined folly. The beginner's mind of the player walks on a path of joy.

A Pedagogy of Creation: *una pedagogia dell'arte*

The Player is the Creator of their own work. The aim of a pedagogic process is to train creators capable of developing their own artistic voice in an autonomous way *(arte)*. It's a work that inspires not only theatre artists, but any person who is interested in creating their own life journey. Pedagogy is a space of research and practice, where the world is recreated every day. The pleasure of learning and teaching provokes the learners to develop their own unique, poetic identity and theatrical folly. Both the teachers and the students are servants of the creative process.

A Pedagogy of States

Play is a particular state of consciousness and each theatrical genre flows from a specific ***state***. The ability to reach this state in order to play and to create from it is the essence of the shape- shifting vitality of the actor. Each form, each character, each mask, each movement, each story, is the threshold to a non-ordinary state of consciousness. To play is to participate in an enhanced state of vitality, to be aware of connections and to constantly ***re-act*** to movement. Play is ecology in motion.

A Pedagogy of Initiation

The actor, as a poet, player and creator, is a *shapeshifter*, as well as a *stateshifter*, journeying in the footsteps of ancestral shamans and working every day to refine and develop their perception of reality, and to train their expressive skills. For this purpose, several pedagogical tools are creatively integrated within a unique "alchemical pot." In the journey of the discovery of the world, the artist encounters themselves in a new state of self-awareness and transforms their inner world into a conscious instrument for poetry. The artist faces their own powers and wounds, often merged in a mysterious alchemy of awareness. The pedagogic purpose is not only to train theatre artists, but to accompany them towards a wider state of consciousness and further levels of awareness, in order to work consciously with personal powers: emotions, life experiences, visions, inspirations, dreams, wounds and desires.

The development of a Pedagogy

This Pedagogic Training emerges from my desire and urgency to integrate, in a unique and coherent form, my pedagogic process of practice, research and experimentation over the last three decades. This process has followed a highly multi-disciplinary path: natural

sciences, theatre art, pedagogy, education, somatic psychology, awareness practices and ecological science and design.

At the end of my training in Paris, Jacques Lecoq gave me this title, for my final creation project (the "*commande*"): *"Dans un croisement une chance est donnée"* (In a crossing/merging/cross-over, a chance is given"). In a way, developing this title has been my "pedagogic commande." It involves crossing disciplines to find new opportunities, new ways.

The journey *(le voyage)* developed by Jacques Lecoq is a pedagogic structure that holds a great value because it is rooted in the very dynamics of life. It follows step by step the journey from the observation of life to its poetic transposition in theatre. It's an artistic and theatrical training that awakens and refines the Poetic Body of the actor-creator.

In 30 years of intimate work within this form as a student, assistant and teacher with Lecoq, and then in my autonomous experiences at Kiklos and Helikos and in various other schools inspired by Lecoq's work, I have had the chance to explore this journey in detail, finding my own relationship with it, as well as my own way to continue further and beyond that form.

The fundamental intuition that I have been following is that it is a journey of poetic and personal initiation: a path that, by considering Nature as the main master, leads the person into a way, a *Tao*, a path of knowledge and understanding of the mysteries of life and of her/his role in it. My contribution has been to deepen the journey of the actor within this form, and to reunite the personal with the poetic, which, in the Lecoq approach, were kept rigorously separated.

From the perspective of theatre pedagogy, the ancient motto *"know thyself"* is at the roots of my work with Clown and Neutral Mask - the dynamic duo that stands at the doorstep of the whole journey. I would say that my version of this sentence could be: *know thyself, transform yourself into a poem and play.*

If the poet with the Neutral Mask sets off for the discovery of the world, at one point they meet themself as a form of nature. It is precisely at this level that I have developed a pedagogy that expands the consciousness of the artist and nourishes a process of personal and poetic awareness. This pedagogy is both technical and emotional, and it involves the artist in the wholeness of their being: body, mind, soul and spirit. It is a process of integration of different approaches to theatre and different visions of the training of the artist, and it has a fundamental root in somatic psychology, in the sense of the psychological life of the body and the embodied life of the psyche.

Within this work at the edge between the personal and the poetic, I have unfolded the interconnections between the different theatre genres and explored how each of them appeals to different dynamics of the individual and of society, and therefore has unique and peculiar powers and potentials. The notion of "altered states" or "non-ordinary states" has

been crucial in the understanding of the state of playing as the essence of the shapeshifting vitality of theatre.

Integrating the split between "physical" and "psychological"

At the theatrical level, this pedagogic vision stands in the core of the notorious opposition between "physical theatre" and "straight theatre." Or "text-based theatre". This split is well represented in the opposition between the two pedagogies of Lecoq and Stanislavski. They are usually viewed in opposition to each other and often considered as mutually exclusive, but nothing could be more misleading.

Using the terms of Gestalt psychology, with its understanding of perception as a process of emergence of a form *(figure)* from the background *(ground),* we could say that Lecoq starts from the figure to reach the ground, the essence, while Stanislavski starts from the ground to reach the figure. The form emerges from the quantum field of potentials, as a character emerges from the field of potentials manifested in the Neutral Mask, the body that contains all bodies and all characters.

In Lecoq's approach, the actor touches the dramatic by working on the form - the body in space: if we fully commit to the mask, the mask will reveal its drama. The opposite way does work too: first the actor touches the drama, through a text, an emotional memory or other "psychological dynamics," and then they bring it to the space.

Both approaches have their brilliant potentials and their traps.

Lecoq's approach reveals one big danger: the mechanical trap - an exclusive focus of physical technique through timing, rhythm, great physicalization of characters and staging, but little poetic depth. This trap can manifest in works with technical virtuosity and great play but poor writing and the lack of truly compelling stories.

The Stanislavski-based theatre has its own traps too, the main one being what Lecoq called *le jeu psychologique*, or an intellectual way of playing. Ideas delivered through voice and texts, without any engagement of the body in space and without any physical vitality. This trap feeds an intellectual quality of theatre and generates a kind of actor who can't truly "play" on stage, but can just "act."

These different approaches, however, when applied in their core essence, are far from separate. They are actually both viable and fully complementary. If they have been put in conflict, and still are, I think that this is due to historical and cultural backgrounds, as well as to the culture and personality of the founders and of their early students. It is not an intrinsic exclusion. Unfortunately, this misleading conflict has had quite serious consequences, creating the split between text-based and movement-based theatre. This is a truly false separation.

The reality is that *le fond est dans la forme and la forme est dans le fond*. The essence is in the form and the form is in the essence. Something that the ancient Taoist masters knew a long time ago, as well as many native cultures all around the planet.

This split is a variation on the bigger theme of the separation between reason and instinct, between mind and body, between thought and action, theory and experience, above and below, soul and body - and at the core: the separation between matter and spirit. This is a huge and heavy burden of our western culture and mind, one that has provoked the profound split between science and art. The entire society as well as Planet Earth are suffering from this split.

I have worked and researched extensively at the epistemological level of this pedagogy. I use the term *epistemology* in the sense of *the study of the nature of knowledge.* Or *the study of the process of knowing*. Rooted in the experience of the body rather than in a theory about it, this pedagogy can be a "way of knowledge" with powerful potentials. It can integrate itself with other disciplines that use the direct experience of the body as a way of knowledge of nature and the world, and it can provide useful insights and tools to a variety of disciplines and practices.

Integrating this split is a fundamental aspect of the epistemology of this pedagogic training. The actor-poet will consciously enter in their own inner movements as part of the observation of nature. Emotions, before being psychological dimensions, are dynamics: movements in space. They can be discovered and expressed with the tools of movement that Lecoq has defined, as well as explored with the knowledge of the functioning of human psyche and body that comes from the psycho-analytical lineage.

The head is part of the body, the mind moves, and the intellect IS movement. Training the intelligence and the ability to analyze, articulate and talk about the pedagogic and artistic process is a crucial skill of the pedagogue. That is why the training will provide extensive theoretical background to the work. Theory is a space of reflection and intellectual elaboration: it creates a space of discussion, analysis, and creation through questions and synthesis. It provides food for the mind, references, history of ideas, articulation of principles.

Etymology tells us that the word *theory* means something you observe, *a spectacle*. It has the same root of the word *theatre*. A theory is a choreography of ideas and principles, an intellectual performance to attend and enjoy.

A path with multiple roots

In my work a fundamental reference is the theatre pedagogy of Jacques Lecoq and his lineage: Jean Dasté, Jacques Copeau, Suzanne Bing, Amleto and Donato Sartori, Carlo

Mazzone-Clementi, and the everlasting tradition of *Commedia dell'Arte*. At the same time, my pedagogy has an ever- growing number of sources and inspirations that have nourished and inspired it. In parallel with my artistic search, another "journey" has unfolded: a quest for awareness through a variety of experiences, training and personal work.

Among them the most influential sources have been these:

- The lineage of Wilhelm Reich: character analysis, bioenergetics of Alexander Lowen, Breathwork.
- The lineage of Fritz Perls and Gestalt therapy: the here and now, the cycle of contact, the self as a process, psychopathology as adaptation.
- The lineage of Carl Gustav Jung and deep psychology: dreamwork, collective unconscious, archetypes, Archetypal Psychology of James Hillman, Process Oriented Psychology (Process Work) of Arnold Mindell.
- The philosophical and spiritual field of Taoism.
- Theatre of the Oppressed by Augusto Boal, community theatre, theatre in education.
- Puppet theatre.
- My background as a natural scientist has also informed my approach, through ecology, sustainability and, more recently, Permaculture Design.

Each of these paths has gifted the work with very specific and precious ingredients, turning the theatre process and its pedagogy into a delicious recipe for a lot of different palates. I have "crossed" theater with techniques and approaches that usually belong to the realm of therapy. And for therapy I mean a process that consciously explores the field of emotional wounds, in order to gain awareness and re-configure one's own experience and perception of identity and reality. In this "interbreeding" of Lecoq's pedagogy with other body-oriented approaches, a synthesis has appeared. This synthesis has created a uniquely fun path in which my theatrical work has been nurtured by emotional awareness, and my quest for emotional awareness has been nurtured by theatre. Poetic and emotional awareness have become at the same time goals and results of the work.

I would go as far as affirming that the work has become a *theatrical awareness paradigm.* This work can reach far beyond professional theatre. I have been exploring this theatrical pedagogy not only in the training of professional theatre practitioners but also as an instrument towards education, healing, political and environmental action, pedagogic training and psychotherapy. I have worked with human beings coming from all sorts of life paths, ages, states of mind, and cultures. The work seems to provide a solid ground for poetic awakening to everyone and it reconnects theatre to its ancient ritual origin: individual and collective ecstasy. The most recent developments of my work with clown,

bouffons and mask, in many workshops and trainings around the world, have confirmed the direction of the work as based on *"the state."* These developments have inspired me to further define a pedagogic process whereby, giving priority to the state with its emotional and poetical depth, play and writing flow easily into the creation. When movement technique refines the play, theatre can truly reach excellence, becoming a unique and invaluable mirror of the world, as well as a uniquely transformative experience for the artist, and the audience and a precious contribution to the vitality of a community.